



London Seminary

PASTORS TRAINING PASTORS



Martyn Lloyd-Jones
Inaugural Address
London Theological Seminary
October 6th 1977



Dr. Martyn Lloyd-Jones'

INAUGURAL ADDRESS

at the opening of the London Theological Seminary.
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I address you tonight primarily as the Chairman of the Sponsoring Committee which has been responsible for calling this meeting to inaugurate The London Theological Seminary. Before I say anything else I should like to repeat what our chairman has said about our sense of gratitude to Mr. Kensit and the Trustees of the Kensit Memorial College in whose premises we are meeting tonight, and in whose premises the Seminary is going to function. They of course are concerned about the very same things as we are, and it seems to me to be a very happy co-operation of two institutions which are designed and intended to further the same common object.

I have a suspicion that many of you feel that the phenomenon by which you are confronted is that of a poacher turned gamekeeper! I agree that there is a good deal to be said for that feeling! My only defence is that I try always to be open to any conviction produced by facts; and whatever views I may have held in the past, and indeed still hold, I am here because I have been persuaded by the arguments that have been put before me.

I believe we are doing something here tonight which is of very great significance. We are inaugurating a new College, and we are concerned about the whole question of the training for the ministry. I want therefore to take advantage of this occasion to reconsider with you the whole question of

the training for the ministry. That seems to me to be the most significant element in what we are doing here tonight.

Why should this question be reconsidered? There are many reasons, and it is these which have been moving us as members of this Sponsoring Committee. I believe it is true to say that by now everybody virtually is dissatisfied with the existing systems. During the last few months, and very largely as the result of that notorious book 'The Myth of God Incarnate' many have been expressing their amazement and surprise at the state of Theological Colleges. I have seen statements by bishops of the Church of England deploring the obvious gap between what is happening among so-called theologians in Oxford and Cambridge and the ordinary members of the Christian Church. Many of them have said, and said rightly, that these colleges where men are supposed to be trained for the Christian ministry have lost all contact with the members of the Christian Church. It is being recognised more and more that something has to be done.

Some, of course, have reacted strongly against the present state of such Colleges and have tended to say that therefore we do not need any colleges at all. I believe that that is an error, as I am hoping to show as we proceed. Another attitude, which is of concern to all of us at the present time, is the result of the new stress upon experience and the experimental aspect of the Christian faith. We thank God for this emphasis but many such friends are tending to say that

there is no need for ordained ministers as such, and therefore no need, obviously, for training ministers.

A further reason is that there are rumours, and more than rumours, of a move to have Ecumenical Colleges. So far, the various denominations have had their own Colleges; but there is a move afoot now to amalgamate all these and to have Colleges in which men who are going to minister in the various denominations, even including the Roman Catholic Church, are going to be trained together and have a common course of instruction. This immediately stirs within us the feeling that we must have an Evangelical College. I believe this Ecumenical idea will come to pass, partly on economic grounds and various other difficulties. They cannot afford their separate Colleges, so they are going to get together to establish Ecumenical Colleges. The Sponsoring Committee felt very strongly that over against that we must have an Evangelical Seminary, and not only an Evangelical but a distinctively Protestant College. We are living in days, unfortunately, when it is no longer sufficient to talk about being Evangelical. We must emphasise 'Protestant' as well as Evangelical because we stand not only against ecumenicity but very definitely, and in particular, against Roman Catholicism. We are Protestants and this is to be a Protestant Evangelical College. There are Evangelicals today who are not only ready to fraternise, but are fraternising with Roman Catholics, and even considering with favour the possibility of eventually being one with the Roman Catholic Church. So we are Protestants as well as

Evangelicals over against a vague ecumenicity that ultimately includes Roman Catholicism.

Another element or factor which has influenced us is that we have been hearing that certain Free Church evangelical students who are hoping to enter, and some who have entered, Free Church ministries have actually been going to Anglican Colleges for their training. As a Non-conformist and Free Churchman that is something which rouses my ire, and if I had no other reason for supporting this venture, that alone would be sufficient for me! And then, on top of this, it is generally agreed that the existing Colleges for some reason or another – and I hope to deal with some of them – have failed to produce preachers. One of the most alarming and most regrettable aspects of our present Church life is the paucity of preachers of the Word. We have knowledgeable men; but what is needed above everything else is preachers. Many hold the view, and I believe that there is something to be said for it, that the existing Colleges far from producing preachers have on the whole tended to stifle and ruin preachers. There are young men who have gone to College full of zeal for preaching the Word of God who have come out tired intellectually, and weary, and who have lost that first impulse which gave them the desire to become preachers of the Word.

A final reason which I adduce is that we felt that it was essential that the Sponsorship of such a College should be as broad-based as possible. There are among us certain

'empire builders' who are always ready to start their own colleges, so we felt that we must have a College which would be supported by, and which would minister to, the various groupings of Protestant Evangelicals in this country today. The names of the members of this Sponsoring Committee emphasise this wide and broad base on which the College is founded. This is not some personal venture; it is the coming together of Protestant Evangelical groupings in this country to form a college which will serve all the various Free Evangelical Churches.

How do we approach this whole matter of training preachers? I was seriously tempted to deal with the subject solely from the historical standpoint. The history of the Theological Colleges and Seminaries is a very fascinating one. Let me give a hurried bird's eye view of the history of this matter. The Church as we know her started on the Day of Pentecost, and the first preacher under her auspices was a man who, from the modern standpoint had had no training at all – a fisherman, the Apostle Peter. Of course, he and the others had been with our Lord, and they had heard His preaching and His teaching; but there was no formal teaching, no formal training, to make them preachers. Peter stood up and 'filled with the Holy Ghost' he preached; and all those New Testament preachers, with the exception of the Apostle Paul, were similar men. They could be described accurately as 'ignorant and unlearned men' yet they were mighty preachers.

At first that was the position, but gradually that was changed. As the result of the spread of the gospel in the Greek world, and its coming among the philosophers, it was felt that a greater intellectual content was necessary, that the gospel should be defended against the attacks that were made upon it, and that its superiority to every human philosophy should be made clear and manifest. So, slowly, the whole idea of training and preparing men came in, and developed very rapidly until when you come to the Middle Ages and later, you have what is called a kind of scholasticism, and men entering the ministry were taught an admixture of philosophy and biblical teaching. They were taught philosophic systems and Roman Catholic 'dogma', with the result that the gospel in a sense was entirely hidden out of sight.

Then came the Protestant Reformation in the 16th century. Now the Protestant Reformation, while it clearly saw the error of the teaching of Rome and introduced true gospel teaching and preaching, and while it corrected the doctrine, in my opinion did not deal in a fundamental manner with this further matter of training men for the ministry. It tended to take over the general idea of training, and though it gave men a different teaching, the method seems to me to have been very much the same. We can well understand that. They felt that they had to answer the case of Rome, and to point out its dangers to the people. The result was that, speaking very generally, Luther, Calvin and all these great men perpetuated the kind of preparation which had already

been employed. The teaching was changed but in a sense the method was not. The Puritans in a sense went further than the Reformers in this matter, but I would argue that on the whole even they also did not break free, as it were, from this older method, this older approach which had been in vogue for so many centuries.

It is when you come to the 18th century you find that a great change took place which is of very great significance. With the advent of the Evangelical or Methodist Awakening a number of men came into being who were known as Exhorters. These were men who were converted under the powerful preaching of the Methodists, both Calvinist and Arminian. Some of these converts were ordinary workmen, but in the Class meetings and Societies they began to display a gift of speech, and increasingly they were called upon to speak and address meetings. In spite of the fact that they were not trained they became Exhorters or Lay-preachers. The old idea still persisted, so they were not called preachers; they were called Exhorters, because they had not had training. But some of these men were very powerful preachers, some of them exceptionally so; but as they had not received the customary training they were not ordained. This persisted to the end of that century.

But when you come to the last century, the 19th century, something happened which we must examine very carefully. As the century proceeded it was felt that people had now become more educated and more learned, and so a sense

of increasing dissatisfaction was felt with these simple, unlettered, sometimes uncouth preachers; and a corresponding demand arose for educated men in the pulpit. So the movement in the direction of Theological Colleges and Seminaries was given a very great impetus; and it developed very rapidly until you arrive at the full-blown idea of Theological Colleges and Seminaries which flourished in the latter half of the 19th century, and which has persisted more or less until today. Great emphasis was placed upon training, upon knowledge and learning – a knowledge of philosophy and a knowledge of Greek and Hebrew. A knowledge of classical Greek was deemed to be essential in order to interpret the Greek of the New Testament truly, and so on. Now this became the pattern, and so men were sent to such Colleges to receive this education and learning and culture. That is what we have inherited.

My suggestion is that we have arrived at a point when all that has got to be reconsidered if we really want to have an efficient training of men for the ministry. I must not digress by pointing out that all that has been done during the last century has more or less come to nothing, and that we have undergone almost a complete circle. Having emphasised for so long, as the authorities did, that you must have a knowledge of classical Greek, it was then discovered that the Greek that was actually used was so-called Koiné Greek, a much more common Greek; and that a knowledge of classical Greek might even be misleading in this respect. Not only so, they paid great attention to the dates of origin of

the various books of the New Testament, and with great confidence they taught that most of the books of the New Testament were not written until the end of the first century and some even in the second century. But by now Dr. John Robinson, of all men, has argued cogently that these books were written before A.D. 70; so all the fuss and the bother, and all the weariness that has been caused to endless generations of poor students who have had to grapple with this nonsense, has all proved to be completely valueless and useless!

That, then, is the position. What are we to do? The conclusion at which we as a Sponsoring Committee have arrived is that the whole question must be faced anew. We must make a fresh start; and we must not content ourselves with a mere modification of the present system and the present position. That, I believe, has been the main weakness and defect of the various Bible Colleges that have come into being especially since the end of the last world-war. They were established on the basis – and I was involved in the discussions – that what we needed to do was to safeguard the teaching; but the method of training was never considered at all. It was felt that all that was necessary was that we should guarantee that the teaching would be Evangelical; but they made the fatal mistake of allowing the curriculum to be determined by the liberal outlook, sometimes even by secular Universities such as the London University. A secular University, which is what the London University is, was to determine the curriculum and

the syllabus that Evangelical ministerial students are to study! That was the fatal blunder; and so we have to reconsider this matter from the very foundation. We are not concerned, therefore, merely to start yet another College: we are starting an entirely different Seminary, something which is based, not on the tradition we have inherited, but which is based rather upon our understanding of the New Testament teaching. We propose that an entirely new start should be made.

I therefore repeat my question; What is needed? I have already answered the question by asserting that the primary need is for preachers. God has done His greatest work in the world in the Church through preachers; and never was there a greater need of preachers than today. I am emphasising 'preachers' rather than teachers. What is the difference between a preacher and a teacher? The teacher is one who, essentially, imparts information, passes on knowledge. I am prepared to argue that there is less need of teachers today than there has been for a long time. This is so because the general level of culture and of knowledge is higher than it has ever been. Members of churches today, and others, have had a good education, speaking generally. They are able to read many translations of the Scriptures which were not available before. There are endless Commentaries, and there is ample literature on religion in general, on theology and various other subjects, easily and cheaply available; so my argument is that there is less need today to give people information which they can find in

books for themselves. The greatest need is not for teaching or lecturing; it is for preaching.

What is preaching? Preaching is proclamation; it is the powerful presentation of the great message of the Bible. It includes evangelism of course. The preacher should be an evangelist, and should know how to bring people to conviction of sin and to faith in the Lord Jesus Christ, as the Apostle Paul tells us he always did (Acts 20;21). He reminds the Ephesians that what he did amongst them was to tell them about 'the repentance that is toward God and the faith that is toward the Lord Jesus Christ'. We need men who are able to do this with great power; but at the same time they must be able to build up the saints. I have often affirmed that the main function of the preacher is inspirational. It is not merely to dole out information, or lecture on the books of the Bible, or lecture on doctrine. He can tell people where they can read this. He does so up to a point of course, but his supreme task is to inspire the people. The people are reading the Bible, but they do not see much in it. The business of the preacher is to bring the Bible alive to them, to show them what is in it, to thrill them as they hear it from him, and then as they read it for themselves. He is to move people. He is to remember that they have hearts as well as heads, and that unless people are moved by the preaching, their head-knowledge may even be a danger to them. To produce live living witnesses, 'epistles of Christ', is the business of the preacher. He is not simply to give people knowledge and information. He is to produce saints, and

these saints, as they mix with others, will be the means of convicting them and bringing them to the Church. So the supreme need is that of preachers, not mere teachers, still less lecturers.

But the man of God is also to be a pastor. Because of the stresses of modern life, in a very special way, the pastoral side is an increasingly important one. There, then, is the need; and what we are aiming at in this new Seminary is to supply the answer to it.

How can we do so? Let us start with our ideas with respect to the students. What are our desiderata with regard to the student? This is most important, because in many ways the wrong view has been held for many years. The churches and ministers – let us admit it – have been far too ready to 'lay hands suddenly' on any man. If any young man says vaguely that he would like to go into the ministry we immediately encourage him to do so. We may be quite wrong in doing so. This is a very serious and most crucial matter. I assume that we are all agreed that the minister is not a professional man. No man should go into the ministry as a profession. What then do we desiderate? Well, he must be a converted man. He must be a man who is aware of new life in himself; but he must be a spiritually-minded man also. This is essential. He must have a sense of burden for the souls of men. He must be aware of a call which he finds irresistible. I have always maintained that if a man can stay out of the ministry he should do so. Every minister and

preacher should be able to say, 'The love of Christ constraineth me'.

He must also be a humble man. This is again crucial. We read in the life story of George Whitefield that he felt that this task of the preacher, the minister, was so high and so sacred that he felt completely unworthy of it, and had to be persuaded by many others to go on with it. This sense of unworthiness seems to have gone, doesn't it? People rush into preaching and into pulpits lightly. The man who is to be a preacher must be a man who is aware of a sense of awe. He must be a humble man because of the greatness of the task. I surely need not say anything about his character. By character I mean in particular that the minister must not be a difficult man. I fear that I have known some ministers who have been very difficult; and their poor flock have had to accommodate themselves to him, to the preacher. This should never be the case. Over the years I have discouraged quite a number of men from entering the ministry because I felt that they were possessors of such a temperament, such a psychological make-up, that they were such awkward men, that anybody going to seek help from them would be ill at ease in their presence, and would more or less have to put the minister at ease! A minister, a man who preaches, who does pastoral work, must be of such a character, such a type, that people do not have difficulty in approaching him.

Those are general matters; but there are certain special matters upon which we must insist. A preacher should be a man of personality. That term unfortunately is much abused at the present time. People talk of 'television personalities' – nothing but grinning ninnies! That is not what I mean by personality. I mean a man of strength, an arresting man, a man with an element of command about him. He has to stand in a prominent position; so a negative personality is surely a defect in any man who is going to be a preacher. He must also be a man of ability. Obviously if he is going to help others he must be a man of ability. He must know how to think, he must know how to study, but above all he must know how to speak. A man may be a very good man, he may be a very godly man, but if he cannot speak except in a halting, stumbling manner, he has no business to be in the pulpit. By definition the preacher is a speaker, a proclaimer. So he must have a gift of speech. I have referred to the 18th century and the class-meetings, and how they detected this gift in some of the converts. In their class-meetings they would find that there were certain men who could pray more freely than others, who could speak more freely not only in giving their experience, but in giving their opinion upon a verse. It was thus discovered that they were natural preachers; and so the people would then urge them to speak regularly. They had a speaking ability. This seems to have been largely forgotten during the present century, and it has led to very woeful and sad results. Furthermore, the prospective preacher must have the confidence of the Church to which he belongs. This is, again, most important;

and we are very concerned to emphasise this in connection with this College. Our desire is that everything that shall be done here should be closely in touch with the churches from which the students and the candidates come. They are to remain in contact with the churches constantly, with their minister, their deacons, elders if they have any. We are very insistent upon the fact that men should have the confidence of their churches and should remain in contact with them.

When we come to the tutors I need not say much. What I have to say is inevitable in the light of what I have been saying about the students. The tutors must not be 'academics' primarily. Theological teachers and tutors have often been academics who know nothing about Church life, who know nothing about handling people, and, often, who cannot preach. Such have been the men who have been teaching others how to be preachers and pastors! It is idiotic. We must have men who are themselves pastors and preachers and not mere academics; and the men we have appointed as tutors of this London Theological Seminary are men who conform to this pattern. They are men, incidentally, who have been to colleges either in Oxford or Cambridge or London University, and some of them have even been to two of them. So they are men of learning, men of academic knowledge and standing; but we have not appointed them for that reason. We have appointed them because they are also men who are preachers, and who have warm pastoral hearts, because they are men who are spiritually minded and concerned about revival in the Church. Such are the

members of the Faculty of this new Seminary. Not one of these men is leaving his church. They are all continuing as ministers and pastors in their local churches, but they are giving this extra time, taking on this extra task and labour, in order to train preachers and pastors for the future.

We come now to the question of how they are to train these students. I start by saying that it is unlike every other kind of training. It is entirely unique. It is entirely different from the study of science or philosophy or literature or art or any other subject. This is so because every Christian in a sense has the same knowledge as the preacher and the pastor has. It is a question of degree. When you take up any other subject you virtually start knowing nothing. If you want to study medicine or science your personality as such is not involved; but here it is involved, and, in addition, every Christian is a man who has a certain minimum knowledge. Our entire approach therefore has to be very different. We start by realising that here we are in a new realm, an entirely different realm; and the matter must not be considered in an academic or scientific manner. It must be considered always in a spiritual manner. I came recently across a statement by Anselm who was many centuries ago Archbishop of Canterbury. He wrote a book 'Cur Deus Homo' and in it he said something which we must bear in mind, and which is the justification for any training at all – 'As, on the one hand, right order requires that we believe the deep things of the Christian religion before presuming to subject them to the analysis and test of reason; so, on the other hand, it looks to

me like indolent neglect if, already established in the faith, we do not take the trouble to gain an intellectual intimacy with what we believe'. Note that he says that you believe first. Reason is not the controlling factor; this is supra-reason, it is above and beyond reason. He says we must start with belief and not with reason and philosophy. But he goes on to say that it is very unreasonable, on the other hand, it is 'indolent neglect' if we say that because we have faith we do not need to go any farther. We should now try to reason out and to understand, as far as we can with your enlightened spiritual reason, the things we have already believed in the realm above reason. That seems to me to be the basis from which we start.

But let me emphasise that we are not interested in mere scholarship or any kind of scholasticism. That has been, as I have said, the tragedy of the last 100 years in particular. The men who have been concerned with Theological education during the past century remind me forcibly of the Pharisees and Scribes of whom our Lord said that 'they tithe mint and rue and anis and forget the weightier matters of the law'. They have wasted time and energy and wearied the poor students and, in turn, members of congregations, with details of so-called historical and literary criticism, and in quoting authorities; and in the meantime the great principles of the Christian faith have been forgotten. It is not surprising that some of these Colleges have been closed and that their premises are being sold. We are concerned here with spiritual knowledge.

That brings me to my next point which is that there are to be no examinations in this College. You see, we are departing entirely from what has been customary. Colleges founded on the wrong idea have had examinations, and have gone in for degrees and diplomas. We are turning our backs upon that entire outlook. The men who come here to be trained are not going to be regarded as children, or placed under a law. We are not going to tell them when they must get up in the morning and when they are to go to bed, and how they must spend their time. We are assuming that they are men who are called of God and who feel a burden of the times in which we live. If they waste their time they will be proclaiming that they will be disasters in the ministry if they are ever called by a church. We are not interested in diplomas and degrees which do not belong to this realm. There is a sense in which it is almost blasphemous that there should be examinations in connection with this knowledge with which we are concerned.

At this point I venture to offer a criticism of a great Evangelical scholar who at the opening of a famous Seminary nearly 50 years ago uttered these words: 'We believe' he said 'that a Theological Seminary is an institution of higher learning whose standards should not be inferior to the highest academic standards that anywhere prevail'. I dissent from that completely and entirely; and regard it as an entirely wrong approach. This College is not an 'academic institution' and it should not be compared in any way with

any institution of higher learning. We are in an entirely different realm here. So we are not going to have any degrees or diplomas or even any examinations. The students will proclaim what they are by their response to this; and when they appear before churches it will be obvious to the church members.

We start, in other words, on this assumption, that preachers are born. No college, or any other institution, can ever produce a preacher. That they can do so has been another of the fallacies of the past hundred years. A preacher is born, as such, and I am not sure but that the same applies to pastors. However, they need to be helped in the development of the gifts they have, in order that they may become effective preachers and pastors. This being a Theological Seminary, no women will be admitted, and the students will not be trained here for posts as religious teachers or instructors in schools. We are out to produce preachers and pastors, not experts in religious education, not even 'foreign missionaries' as such. Preachers and pastors. Such men may go of course to and preach in other countries, but we are not concerned here as most Bible Colleges are in that wider programme.

We agree that these men, whom we have defined and described, need some further help. What are we going to give them? Our idea is that we should provide here primarily a basic teaching. This is not to be a college to produce experts or specialists. It is to produce men who will be

preaching Sunday by Sunday to congregations of ordinary people. Should a student appear who has a greater aptitude for study than the average, and who feels that he would like to go on to obtain further knowledge or learning or instruction, and to become a specialist in some branch or other, he will be of course, at full liberty to do so; but the object of this Seminary is not to produce such men. May I use, to illustrate this point, an analogy from the realm of medicine. The great fallacy in medical training over a very long period of time has been that instead of training men to be general practitioners, they have been training them to be specialists. Here in the great London hospitals where training is given all sorts of rare diseases are met, and unusual and difficult cases are seen; and so the poor student, the qualified student, generally goes out into practice knowing a great deal about rare exceptional diseases but often feeling that he knows very little about the common cold or some of the childish ailments with which he will have to deal in his surgery day by day. At long last this has been recognised, and medical students are now given training by general practitioners. But in the past it was not so, and medical doctors had all this abstruse and rare knowledge which was of little value in general practice. Using that analogy we are concerned here primarily about 'general practitioners', preachers of the Word regularly Sunday by Sunday in their churches and chapels. If they want to go on to specialise they are at full liberty to do so; but this College, in particular, does not cater for that.

What then will be taught here? The first thing, of course, is knowledge of the Bible, because a preacher is one who is going to expound the message of the Bible. What does this involve? We start with the vexed question of languages – Hebrew and Greek. As the article written by Mr Graham Harrison – one of the tutors – has indicated we propose to give students sufficient instruction on this matter to enable them to use the Commentaries in an intelligent manner. Much of the trouble in the past has been due to the fact that students have had to struggle and labour with Greek and Hebrew. This has not proved to be of much help to them when they have become ministers because they do not know enough to pit their opinion against the authorities who write the Commentaries. But they have had to waste much time over this.

But there are those at the present time, as there have been before, who dispute and deny what I am asserting. I heard of a youngish minister recently who had said in a conference that unless a man had a thorough knowledge of Hebrew and Greek he could not possibly be a preacher. The great authority, whom I have already quoted, who gave that address nearly 50 years ago, said the same. He said that if you are to tell what the Bible says you must be able to read the Bible for yourself, and you cannot read the Bible for yourself unless you know the language in which it was written. That, to me, is an extraordinary statement to make. Such men hold the view that unless a man has a knowledge of Hebrew and Greek he cannot be a preacher of the Bible.

What is the answer to them? I have already given one answer. The Apostles could not come up to this standard; and not only the apostles, but also the men to whom I have referred in the 18th century. Some of the greatest preachers in the 18th century were not only men who did not know any Greek or Hebrew, some of them had virtually had no school education whatsoever. Some of those who preached in Wales had had some three or six months in a school where they were taught a little English. This is surely a very serious matter. Charles Haddon Spurgeon was never in a Theological Seminary, neither was Joseph Parker, and they were the two greatest English preachers of the last century. The same applies to others who are well known because of their great preaching ability and their books of sermons.

So, to say that a man cannot preach, and cannot even read his Bible if he does not know Greek and Hebrew, I am afraid must be categorised as sheer nonsense. This is most serious for it seems to me to show an ignorance of the spiritual character of the biblical message. How anyone who has ever read the 1st epistle to the Corinthians chapter 2 can make such statements I cannot understand. We are not in the realm of things natural; these things are 'spiritually discerned', are understood in a spiritual manner. A man does not understand the Bible simply by knowing Greek or Hebrew. He understands the Bible because he has the Spirit of God in him. 'The princes of this world' says Paul, did not know and receive this message, and they rejected Christ; 'But God hath revealed them unto us by His Spirit: for the

Spirit searcheth all things, yea, the deep things of God'. He goes on to say 'We have received, not the spirit of the world, but the Spirit which is of God; that we might know the things that are freely given to us of God. Which things also we speak, not in words which man's wisdom teacheth, but which the Holy Spirit teacheth'.

The key to the understanding of the Bible is not a knowledge of the original languages. You can have such knowledge and still be ignorant of the message – as so many are and have been, unfortunately. It is the man who has a spiritual understanding who understands the Word of God. Of course, as the Protestant Reformers, and Tyndale and others said, the Word of God must be in a language that a man can understand. But today, we have it in a language we can understand. We have it in English in many versions and translations; so what preachers need today above everything else is the power of the Spirit illuminating their minds. John in his First Epistle in chapter 2, verses 20 and 27 teaches, 'You have no need that anyone teach you'. Why? Because they had an 'unction', an 'anointing'. So to say that a man cannot read his Bible, and that he cannot preach if he lacks a knowledge of Greek and Hebrew seems to me a serious misunderstanding of the biblical message, and the true character of preaching. True preaching is the conveying of this message. The Early Church did this even when she had not got our New Testament documents. They preached a message which they had heard, and had believed, though they were 'ignorant and unlearned men'

who knew nothing of the 'nuances' of Hebrew and Greek deemed so essential today.

What is needed by preachers today is a sufficient knowledge of Greek and Hebrew to enable them to use their Commentaries, and to read the many translations available in an intelligent manner, and to be able to follow the argumentation of the authorities for one view rather than another. No student who comes here – indeed I go further – 99 per cent of students who go any place of learning, will ever know enough Greek and Hebrew to argue with the great professors. So what is needed is this basic knowledge of these languages. They have the Bible in a language they understand; and what they need now is to be taught the Bible message – the whole message, and the particular messages of the particular books – in a more thorough manner.

So, they will be trained in what is called 'exegesis' – a true understanding of what the text is saying. But still more important 'hermeneutics' – the grasping of the message, and how to use this, how to convey it, how to apply it, how to present it to the people. A man may be an expert at exegesis but if he is poor at hermeneutics he will be a very poor preacher.

Moreover, the students will be taught Theology. But they will not be taught philosophy here. We have not catered for any teaching of philosophy except in apologetics which will come

at the end. Theology is knowledge of God derived from the biblical revelation. Theology is most important; some of us have been trying to teach and to emphasise this for many years, and have held it to be 'the queen of the sciences'; but we must realise that there are certain dangers connected with teaching Theology. Increasingly I have come to the view that the teaching of Theology should never be separated from the Bible. If I were pressed hard I would be prepared to say that Theology should never be taught except through sermons! The great danger is to turn Theology into an abstract, theoretical, academic subject. It can never be such because it is 'knowledge of God'. So the students here are to be taught biblical Theology – the doctrines that emerge as you study through the Bible carefully. Then, having got their biblical theology, they must learn how to systematise that, and how to put it all together in a more logical form in order that it may control their thinking and preaching. But it is most important that it should be presented in the right way, never abstractly, but always as something which comes out of the Scriptures.

What is the purpose of Theology? Here, again, there have been many mistakes in the past. Theology has to be handled very carefully. What is the function of Theology and Doctrine? First and foremost it is never meant to be a prison house. It is never meant to be a strait-jacket. There have been many men for whom Theology has been just that. They are in a strait-jacket, hemmed in by their Theology, and always afraid that they may say something wrong. That

is not the business of Theology. Theology is not a prison, or something which fetters a man; it is to be thought of, rather, in terms of what the skeleton, the bony structure of a man's body is to his body. Or, if you like, Theology can be compared to the scaffolding that you put up when you are going to erect a great building. It must be there if you are to have good preaching: but you must not preach it in a skeletal or structural manner. It is there to give body to the sermon, and to safeguard you from saying anything wrong or from going astray. Theology, again, may be compared to railway lines which guarantee that you are going in the right direction and make sure that you are going to arrive at the right destination. But it implies movement! It is not something restricting, prohibiting, that shuts you down, something that inhibits freedom and liberty and power. The moment a man is hemmed in and tied down by his Theology he is showing that incidentally he is a very poor theologian, and he certainly has a wrong view of the purpose of Theology.

Theology means a knowledge of God, and the greater the theologian the more he should 'bow down in the presence of His Majesty'. The end and object of Theology is to make a man say 'great is the mystery of godliness'; and if it does not bring him to that he had better examine himself carefully. The business of the tutors is so to present Theology that it leads to that wonderful result. Theology is that which tells me, indeed commands me, 'Take thy shoes from off thy feet, for the ground on which thou standest is holy ground'. You

cannot discuss Theology while smoking pipes or cigarettes or drinking beer. It cannot be done in a jocular light-hearted manner. It means knowledge of God, so it must be done 'with reverence and with godly fear'. That is the end and object of Theology. So the students will be taught that while all true preaching is theological, they are not to preach theology.

What else will be taught? Church History. I regard this as extremely important. It includes the history of the great doctrines, how they came into being, how they developed, and the disputes concerning them. We live in an age of transition, an age which is doubting everything; so we can learn a great deal from the past. We are back again in a situation similar to that in the early centuries of the Christian era; so this history of doctrine is going to be of extreme importance. Not only doctrines but also the history of the denominations. The denominations are talking about amalgamating, of becoming one great church; and some people are fighting a kind of last stand in ditches for their particular denomination. Most of them do not know why they belong to that particular body, and they have no idea as to how their denomination ever came into existence. Their attitude is, 'It is my denomination, and I am going to fight for it to the last drop of my blood'. So it is good that people be taught how the denominations first came into being. That is a part of Church History. So are also the biographies of the saints of God that have adorned the Church. How wonderful it all is! These young men are to be exhorted to read such

histories, not merely to obtain information, but also to keep them humble, so that when they think that they are great preachers, and begin to be puffed up, the reading of a little about a man like Whitefield will soon bring them to the conclusion that they have never preached at all, and are never likely to do so! Church History also includes the stories of revivals and spiritual awakenings. We are living in a barren age spiritually; things are difficult and the churches are having to struggle. Our greatest need is a mighty spiritual awakening, a great revival of religion. The young men who study here will be told about such great events in the past, and will be directed to books which will give them yet greater knowledge about them.

What of Apologetics? It should only come in at this point because its value and function is mainly negative. Its business is to refute the arguments brought against the Christian faith, and to expose the futility of the teaching of the various cults and ideas that are round and about us at the present time. Ministers and pastors of churches are constantly having to deal with either members of their churches, or hearers in their congregations, who suddenly have heard of a cult which seems to offer much more than they have, and they are tending to join such movements. They must be able to tell them why they should not do so. There have been institutions and colleges which have been virtually controlled by apologetics; but that is surely entirely wrong. That is to be negative; but we are to be positive. We must certainly know something about the arguments against

false teaching, and we must be able to 'contend for the faith;' and that is the place of apologetics. But it only comes in at that point.

There is no time to say anything about the pastoral side. As I have said there is a sense in which pastors are born, but they can be helped and encouraged by men who have long experience at such work, and also warned of certain pitfalls. Men need help about such matters, and that will be provided for them here. But we have made no provision for the teaching of psychology. That has been the vogue for years – pastoralia, psychology etc. But pastors are men called to deal with problems of a spiritual nature, and that can be done primarily out of our knowledge of the Word of God.

To sum up, what is the business of this College? What do we hope it is going to do? Let me quote some words written by Peter Brown in his excellent biography of the great St. Augustine – 'The problem is no longer one of training a man for a task he will later accomplish' (That is not the business of a Theological Seminary.) 'It is one of making him wider – of increasing his capacity, at least, to take in something of what he will never hope to grasp completely in this life.' That is the most you can do for any man called to the ministry. Here a man comes; he has been converted, born again, and he has been reading his Bible. He has a certain amount of knowledge. The business of this College is to make him 'wider', not in the sense of going in for a study of philosophy, but to widen the knowledge he already has, to give him a

deeper understanding, to make him a more profound thinker. Indeed if I were asked to sum it up in one word, and asked what is the main function of such a Seminary I would say that it is to teach men to think, so that when they have left the College they can, and will, go on thinking, and not simply turn to the notes which they took down when they were in College, and read out the answers, when they are asked certain questions. The tragedy of so many men who have been to Theological Colleges and Seminaries is that they have never really thought after they have left College. They have lived on what they were told and took down in a mechanical dictation system in their Seminary, and they simply refer to the notes they took down then. What happens in college should be only a beginning. Its purpose is to widen a man, to increase his capacity to take in something of that which he will never hope to grasp completely in this life. This is so because it is a knowledge of God. The business of the College is to give men a greater love of the Word than they have ever had, a greater desire to dig into its profundities and its mysteries, to read everything they can which will help them to that end, and then to go on doing this, to go on learning and increasing and developing in every respect until they are called home to their eternal reward. And above that it is, as I said, to inspire these men, to send them out with a burning desire to preach the 'unsearchable riches of Christ'. If men's hearts are not warmer when they go out from this college than when they came in, then these tutors will have failed.

I was reading the other day a statement in a letter written by a man called Robert Roberts of Clynog. He was a Welshman who lived at the end of the 18th century and was a seraphic preacher. He came up to preach in London for eight weeks in 1797 to his fellow countrymen. He was not very good at English, but he was a wonderful Welsh preacher. While he was here in London he visited some of the English churches. He found them packed out with great congregations; and among other places he went to Whitefield's Tabernacle in Tottenham Court Road. Concerning that particular visit he wrote to a friend saying, 'I felt while I was there a groaning in my heart and spirit which said' (quoting now from Genesis 22) 'Behold the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?' Then he went on, 'Here is an altar, here is an offering but where is the fire? Here I am looking at Whitefield's pulpit, but where is his God?'

The business of a College is to help these future preachers to provide the wood, and to provide the offering – which in a sense is the knowledge of salvation in our Lord Jesus Christ. This is what we can do; but if the fire does not descend upon it, it will be lifeless, and it will be more or less useless and valueless. You may be in the pulpit of Whitefield, you may have Whitefield's knowledge, and even more than he had – for he was not a very learned man – but the secret of Whitefield was his God, and without Him we avail nothing. Our great concern is that this Seminary should not be a 'dry as dust' academic institution, trying to produce men with first

class honours and high degrees and diplomas awarded by secular universities such as the University of London. No! We are hoping to encourage men who will be able to put everything in order on the altar so that the fire of God The Holy Spirit may descend upon it; and we have every confidence that the members of this Faculty whom we have appointed, and who are so ready to give their services, will never lose sight of that objective. We have every confidence that their greatest desire is that the fire may descend upon the offering that is on the altar. Let us pray for them, and pray for the prosperity and the future of this Seminary. Pray also for the students who shall come here. Do everything you can to help them and to encourage them. Pray for the members of the Faculty and the students, that they may be given strength and understanding and, above all, spiritual insight, so that everything that shall be done here shall redound to the praise and the honour and the glory of the great God whom it is our privilege to try to serve.

London Seminary

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